

Let that sink in.

The ultimate rewards program

Part of the magic of the Barefoot Money Meals is that you get to interrupt the pattern of regular dinners. Remember, you're competing against sophisticated marketers who have been gaming teenagers for generations, so a lecture on the dangers of credit isn't going to work . . . no matter how much you try to jazz it up.

Actions speak louder than words. So instead, at this Money Meal, you're going to do something they'll *never* forget.

You're going to blend your credit card.

Here's you: *Blend* my card? Like . . . in a blender?

Here's me: Yep. Cards in. Lid on. Thirty seconds.

Here's you: But I don't want to blend my credit card! I pay it off in full each month and I get rewards! Besides, it's fine to use one as long as you're *smart* about it.

Here's me: This isn't about you. It's about setting a good example for your kids, who probably don't have your monk-like resolve when they're being marketed to 18 hours a day.

Besides, credit card rewards systems are, like, so 2009. It's no secret that the banks have been playing hokey-pokey with the value of rewards points for years—but right now it's just getting ridiculous.

Case in point: over the past 12 months, the banks have been secretly shutting down, or radically reducing, the value of their rewards systems. According to financial comparison site Mozo, the banks have yanked the value of their rewards points, on average, by a staggering 96 per cent since 2016.

The value of the points—not to mention the restrictions on redeeming them—is a joke.